



Great servant: Bengal veteran Manoj Tiwary has so far played 141 first-class matches, scoring 9908 runs at an average of 48.56 with 29 centuries and 45 half-centuries. K. MURALIKUMAR

cricket, acknowledges that the Ranji Trophy remains unmatched in testing skills. However, he admits that unless there's a rise in financial rewards, upcoming generations may choose to opt out of the demanding competition.

"With so many leagues cropping up, the younger players have a lot of options these days, as compared to our times. If the Ranji Trophy has to stay pertinent, the money needs to increase," says Tiwary, who will lead Bengal in his final season. "The youngsters now know that you don't need a Ranji Trophy to earn money. There are shorter format tournaments that can help them make equal amounts of money, so if you want the brightest of talents to hang in there, the money has to improve."

In 2021, the BCCI revised the match-fee structure to Rs 40,000 per

match-day (1 to 20 matches), Rs 50,000 per match-day (21 to 40 matches), and Rs 60,000 per match-day (40+ matches) for first-class cricket. But there's still a huge pay disparity between first-class cricket and an IPL contract.

Faiz has led Vidarbha to two consecutive Ranji Trophy and an Irani Cup title. Now at the fag end of his career, he believes that the contract system is the way forward if the tournament hopes to survive the test of time. "Everyone is a professional, and at the end of the day, everyone wants a good life. The game requires a lot of sacrifices, and in today's time, if a cricketer has to play first-class cricket, he needs to sacrifice his studies and dedicate a huge amount of time to the game, and even then, there's no guarantee that he will have a long career," Faiz says.

"So, a central contract is the way to go. That way, the players will have security and can concentrate on their game seriously without constantly thinking about what would happen if they got dropped

after one match. It is the need of the hour," he says.

This time, international cricketers like Ajinkya Rahane, Cheteshwar Pujara, Vijay Shankar, and Mayank Agarwal, who are currently not part of the national team, will be representing their respective state sides. Defending champion Saurashtra sees this as an opportunity and a challenge to increase its title count. As in previous seasons, the team relies on experienced players, led by Jaydev Unadkat, for a solid start. In recent years, teams have shifted towards a more aggressive style of play, opting for thrilling contests rather than settling for first-innings leads.

Faiz believes the tournament needs to be marketed better, and there should be more live coverage. "That could eventually open up windows for the teams. It would be perfect if companies came up and sponsored even state teams and spread the game across centres; that would be a step in the right direction," he says.

Is anyone listening?